TCYSA Coaches Clinic (8/15/2023)

Where to Start

Before the season begins, you will want to send an email out to all the families and follow it up with a parent meeting on your first day. Some points to include in your introductory email and meeting are the following.

- A summary of who you are: Why are you coaching? What are some things you like to do outside of coaching? What makes you excited about coaching? This helps parents get to know who will be working with their child during the season.
- Philosophy: Come up with a brief coaching philosophy to share with the team. If you are having trouble coming up with one, search coaching philosophies and find one that stands out to you. My coaching philosophy is "Create a player centered environment where players are comfortable taking risks and making mistakes."
- Sideline conduct: Coaches coach, players play, and parents cheer them on! Educate the parents to avoid using verbs (run, pass, shoot, dribble, pressure, etc.) When a coach is coaching and multiple parents are coaching different ideas, it creates confusion for the players.
- Conduct toward referees: We have a shortage of referees and a shortage of qualified referees. The 12-year referee that could grow into an experienced referee in a few years often ends up quitting their referee path due to sideline (coach and parent) conduct. Coaches, players, and parents will all make mistakes during the season. So will the referees. TCYSA has a zero-tolerance policy toward abusive actions and language toward referees.
- Parent issues: Explain the 24-hour rule. Rarely do conversations, immediately following a game or practice, go well. There are competitive emotions involved that, unfortunately, often do not bring out the best in us. Ask the parents to wait until the next day to contact you with issues. If you receive an email, it is best to ask when a good time is to meet. Face to face conversations that are scheduled have a higher success rate. If you are unable to work out the issue, and the parent continues, reach out to your club for support. You aren't in this alone!

Recreational Soccer

The number one goal of recreational soccer is to have fun, develop skills, and most importantly develop people. Team sports are one of the greatest environments for developing young people. The opportunity to learn how to win, lose, and tie appropriately; learn to lead, learn to follow; learn to work together in group settings with teammates, are all life lessons that players will take with them into adulthood.

Best Practices

There are many best practices when it comes to soccer development. Here are a couple of pointers.

- No Lines, No Laps, No Lectures: We want to avoid long lines that limit player activity and touches on the ball. No laps refers to it is not realistic to soccer conditioning and it takes away from getting touches on the ball. If your players are going to do a warmup run, consider having them do it with a ball at their foot. No lectures is based on the fact that players don't want to hear us as coaches talk for long periods of time. If you are going to call your team in, know the point you want to get across and get in and out. The best practice for retention of what you are looking for is to show them on the field.

- Isolated vs Opposed training: Passing and moving from cone to cone looks good and can be introduced for short periods of time. True soccer development comes through decision making, based on opponent's actions. When there is an opponent involved often the same techniques used in isolated training will not work. Even if it is as small as adding a tagger during a dribbling activity, it can make a huge difference in the rate of development.
- 5Rs: Dick Bates, former Technical Director of England, came up with the 5Rs of training. You can run your whole season based on the 5Rs. They are running, releasing, receiving, regaining, and retaining the ball. You can use these as general principles, or you can be more specific in how it relates to your practice topic.
- Warm up: Pre-pubescent ages don't need an extended dynamic warm up. Instead focus on ABC warmups (agility, balance, and coordination).
- Coaches' toolkit: There are four main actions in our coaching tool kit. These are listed from least intrusive to most intrusive.
    - In flow (coaching during live play)
    - Individual reference (individual coaching point to a player)
    - Natural stoppage (address the group once the ball goes out or play naturally stops)
    - Freeze (Stops everyone during live play. Try to avoid too many freezes as it becomes a stop and go training, without player actions developing)

For more information on different coaching modalities, ideas, and information go to Coaches Corner on the TCYSA webpage. Thank you all for your commitment to the players in our soccer community and if you need any further support please reach out to your club.